

IAS PRELIMS/MAINS

Ecology & Environment



A COMPREHENSIVE COVERAGE

MODULE - 13

WETLANDS - 5

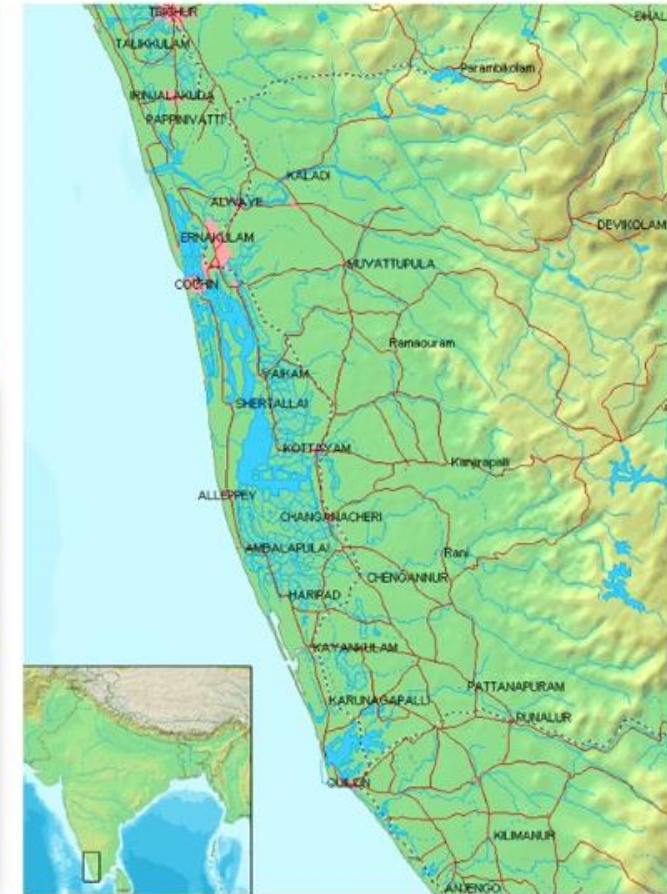
MANGROVES

- Mangroves represent a littoral forest ecosystem.
- These are evergreen forests that grow in coasts, estuaries, backwaters (coastal waters held back on land), marshes and tidal creeks of tropical and subtropical regions.



BACKWATERS OF KERALA

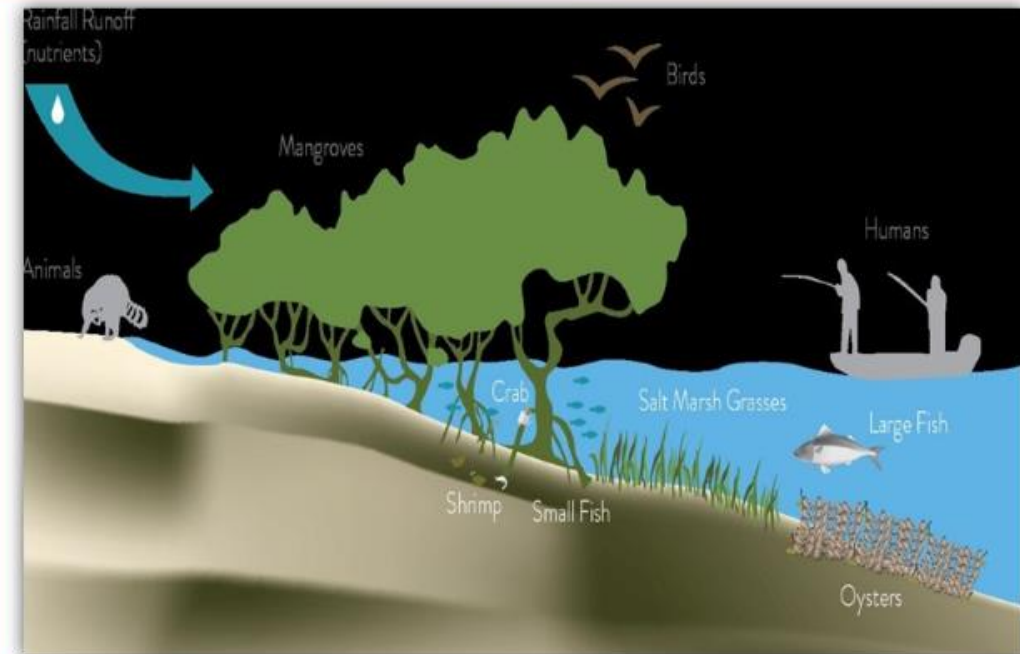
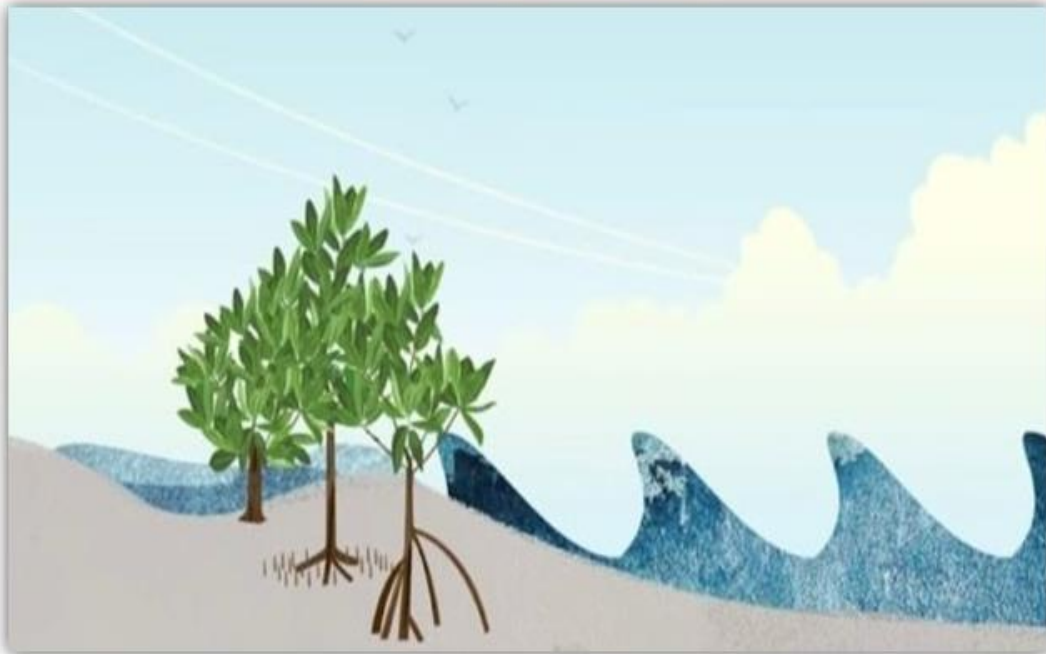
- Since mangroves are located between the land and sea, they represent one of the best examples of an ecotone.
- Mangroves are salt tolerant trees (halophytes).
- Mangroves occur worldwide in the tropics and subtropics, mainly between latitudes 25° N and 25° S.
- They require intense solar radiation to filter saline water through their roots. This explains why mangroves are confined to only tropical and sub-tropical coastal waters.





IMPORTANCE OF MANGROVES

- Mangroves protect the shoreline from the effect of cyclones and coastal erosion.
- Mangroves are an important carbon sink.
- A large variety of wildlife lives and breeds in the mangrove ecosystem, including many species of fish, crab and shrimp, molluscs and sea turtles.
- The trees are home to many nesting, breeding and migratory birds.
- They are breeding and spawning ground for many commercially important fishes.



IMPORTANCE OF MANGROVES

- The mangrove trees are a reliable source of wood for construction and fuel, which is prized for its hardy resistance.
- Plant extracts are collected by locals for their medicinal qualities and the leaves of mangrove trees are often used for animal fodder.
- The forest waters provide local fishermen with a rich supply of fish, crabs and shellfish to sell for income.
- Mangroves encourage tourism.



MANGROVES IN INDIA

- The mangroves of Sundarbans are the largest mangrove forest in the world.
- This mangrove forest is famous for the Royal Bengal Tiger and crocodiles.



MANGROVES IN INDIA

- The mangroves of Bhitarkanika (Orissa), which is the second largest in the Indian sub-continent, are the most species rich mangrove forest in India.
- Mangroves of Pichavaram and Vedaranyam in Tamil Nadu are degraded mainly due to construction of aquaculture ponds and salt pans.



MANGROVES IN INDIA

In Gujarat (north-west coast) mangroves are found mainly in Gulf of Kachchh and the Kori creek.



MANGROVES IN INDIA

- In size, mangroves range from bushy dwarf mangroves found in Gulf of Kutchh, to taller species found in the Sunderbans.
- On the Andaman & Nicobar Islands, the small estuaries, and lagoons support a dense and diverse undisturbed mangrove flora.
- The Sundarban mangroves occupy the largest area followed by Andaman-Nicobar Islands, Gulf of Kachch in Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu.



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For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

For Information:

info.learningspacedigital@gmail.com

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0866 244 44 72

98499 42299

94415 27588